The Bright Zone

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32238805.

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General Audiences

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F, F/M

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

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Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Grizzlor (She-Ra), Octavia (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Magicat Queen (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
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The Bright Zone

by Cloudiana

Summary

Decades ago, a portal opened over the skies of Etheria, and two strange ships crashed on its surface. The renegade refugee First Ones who landed in the Scorpion Kingdom, and the Horde warlord who crashed in the kingdom of Brightmoon were welcomed with open arms . . . with mixed results. Now, the royal family has gone missing, and the Horde is leading a crackdown on all magic users in Brightmoon, remaking the land in his own despotic image.

Adora of the Royalist Resistance and Princess Catra of Halfmoon gain a reputation for their daring raids against the invaders, one that only grows when Adora finds a strange sword, but on the other side of the conflict, a secret magic-user and the Horde's golden boy forge a bond of their own.

TLDR; Catradora and Glimbow Roleswap AU

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Chapter 1

The Magicat kit curled up in the corner of her cage when she heard the voices. “Let go of me,” a kid shouted. “Traitors!” A body slammed against the side of the steel truck. Someone shouted in pain. A moment later, the short crackle of a stun prod cut through the air, and the struggle stopped.

“Damn brat got me in the eye,” one of the soldiers growled as she threw the transport doors open. “Right where the hairball scratched me.”

The kit stayed quiet. The Horde truck was dark, but she didn’t want to take any risks. It was sheer luck that her captors hadn’t found the lock pick tucked away in her mane. She didn’t want to risk them spotting the progress she had made on her chains.

“You can’t be too careful Void Scum, Octavia,” a gruff voice complained. Two sets of boots rang out against the hard floor. “Even the pups are dangerous.”

“Well,” she sighed. “At least we got this one off the streets before it could do any damage.” The hum of the forcefield died for a moment. Then, a hard thud landed close to the kit’s head. Her sensitive ears could hear the bones bruise from impact.

“Careful!” Grizzlor shouted. The Magicat froze. She’d been expecting the grunt to toss their new catch into one of the other cells. If she knew they’d be opening the door to hers, she would

have been ready to pounce, but now she had lost the element of surprise.

"What?" Octavia griped. "Our orders are to bring the younger undesirables back to the Fright Zone alive, not unhurt. A little wear-and-tear is expected." A green light flashed on as the force field sputtered back to life. "Besides, I heard Void Scum have thick skulls. I don't think the freaks can even feel pain. They just fake it."

"What do you think Commander Light Spinner wants with them anyway?" Grizzlor asked. "Why can't we just ship them off to the same internment camps as their parents? I think we found at least ten insurgents in that hideout with the brat; it seems easier to toss 'em in all together is what I'm saying."

"That's above our pay grade," Octavia countered. "But as long as we don't have to play babysitter, I'll be happy. If the Commander's plans are painful, maybe I can get tickets." Their cackling faded as they slammed the door shut. When the engine roared back to life, and the transport began moving again, Catra opened her eyes.

The blonde was about her age: around eight or nine. Her blue eyes glowed faintly in the dark. The girl had been disguised as a regular Horde citizen: grey pants and white shirt. But, she wore a modified, sleeveless red vest to go with it. A gold wing pin rested on the collar. It was a stark contrast to the kit's tattered royal, autumn-hued robes. The princess had never seen a First One before; and based on the curious look in her eyes, she had never seen a Magicat.

Wordlessly, the girl locked her thumbs together and flared out the remaining fingers, making a pair of wings with her hands. “Long alive Queen Angella,” she whispered, tapping her hands against her heart.

“Queen Angella?” The tabby Magicat tilted her head in confusion. “Isn’t she dead?”

“What? No!” The other girl sputtered. “The Horde tried to kill them when she and Micah realized what they were planning to do to magic users like us. They fought back, but they were betrayed! Hordak was too strong, so the royal family went into hiding. Until they come back, we’re doing everything we can to kick out the Horde.” Now, the other girl tilted her head. “Haven’t you heard this before? Aren’t you a Royalist too?”

“No,” she responded. “I’m a Magicat, loyal to the Queens of Halfmoon— Cyra and Moira— and the Princess Alliance.”

“Oh,” the blonde said excitedly, scooting towards her. “I didn’t know you were from Halfmoon.”

“Well, I am,” she replied. “My moms would be really mad if I supported someone other than them. Angella is an ally, and the Princess Alliance wants to see Hordak gone, but she’s not my Queen.”

The girl nodded. “My parents always said, ‘Never guess where someone is from by how they look.’” Suddenly, she looked anxiously. “Do you know where they’re taking the grown ups?” She asked, rubbing the back of her neck, flinching at the feel of the anti-magic collar. “I didn’t see what happened to Mom and Dad after they caught me.”

“Obviously I do,” she responded. “Like that dumb face said, the Horde is sending all the grown ups to internment camps.”

“Oh,” she said. “Where are those?”

“How should I know?” She shot back. “You’re the Royalist. Don’t you have spies everywhere?” The Magicat had heard of the people still loyal to the Brightmoon royal family. They’re weren’t many of them left. After the kingdom allowed the Horde to stay, they had cut off communication with the other kingdoms, Halfmoon included. Still, as more and more refugees fled Brightmoon, stories of the guerilla fighters resisting the Horde spread far and wide.

The royalist frowned. “We helped a few spies from other groups, but my family didn’t do any spying,” she explained. “We ran a safe house. After the Horde started rounding up magic users, we left home and started helping others escape.” She grimaced. “We forged documents, made encrypted communicators, and smuggled out anyone who didn’t want to fight. Our group had a secret hideout under our repair shop and everything, but somehow the Horde found us anyway.”

“Why didn’t you just leave Brightmoon?” The Magicat asked. “The Scorpion Kingdom has tons of First Ones colonies. You could have gone there.” It was where the bulk of the First Ones fleet had crashed twenty years ago, around the same time the Horde was first sighted in the Brightmoon royal palace. The old king had allowed many of the strangers to stay within his kingdom, amazed by the wonders they could work with what remained of their technology. Apparently, he was also impressed with their cooking. Though, from what Catra had heard, anyone was welcome in the Scorpion Kingdom.

The blonde looked surprised. “How could we leave? Those people needed our help,” she said as if it were obvious. “Besides, the Horde says we don’t belong here, but they’re liars! We’re Etherians, and Brightmoon is our home. And you have to fight for your home, no matter what!”

The Magicat smiled. The girl looked kinda goofy when she was being self-righteous, but she was still like a little beacon in the dark transport. According to all the rumors she had heard about the First Ones, they were stoic and unreadable. Strange aliens from the void beyond the moons, who had crashed on their planet decades ago with plans to do. . . .something horrible. Untrustworthy and deceitful down to the last one. This girl had her questioning if any of those people had even ever seen a First One.

“Your turn,” the First One said, interrupting her train of thought. “If you’re from Halfmoon, how did the Horde catch you?” Anxiety flashed over her face. “They haven’t invaded have they? I heard rumors but—“

The Magicat cut her off before she could spiral further. “You Royalists did such a good job of screwing with their plans, the Alliance has been able to keep the Horde from spreading. We kicked their busts so bad, Hordak invited my mother to negotiations on behalf of the Alliance. But, it was a trap. He ambushed the delegation. They were too slow to catch me.”

“Wait?” The other girl said. “Your mother was invited? To negotiate? But— that would only— why would— unless she was —“ she gasped. “You’re a princess!?”

“Shhh,” she hissed urgently. “Just call me Catra. I managed to escape the ambush, but these jerks caught me a few days ago. They think I’m just another Magicat, and I don’t want them knowing who I really am, ok?” The Horde hated Princesses, and who knew how many cages they would lock her up in if they knew? “It’s better if they underestimate us for now.”

“Oh! That’s smart,” she said, sticking out her hand. “I’m Adora.” When they shook hands, the First One looked at her excitedly. “So,” she whispered loudly. “What’s your plan?” When Catra didn’t respond, she clarified. “You’re a princess,” she explained, saying the last word so quietly Catra could barely hear it. “Princesses save people. So, you’re gonna save us. Right?”

Catra had only seen eyes that sincere when her mother, Moira, spoke to the troops. Mom had once called it the kind of sincerity that made her think the other person was faking it, and that terrified her once she realized it wasn’t. The girl was looking at her with total and complete trust. Adora really believed Catra was going to save them; her mouth went dry at the thought.

She caught sight of the lock pick in her hands. Her eyes lit up. “You smuggled that past them? Wow!” She said. “I’ve carried secret notes to other royalists before, but I’ve never seen anyone get contraband into a Horde prison!”

“Well, yeah, I did,” the princess responded confidently, brushing aside her doubt. “My mom taught me all about how to hide your weapons from the enemy. We can use it to rip out whatever makes the force field work, get rid of these,” she gestured to their shackles, “and then we jump out of the truck before they even notice we’re gone.”

She shook her head. “They’ll know we escaped if we don’t take care of these first,” she said, pointing to the anti-magic collars around their necks.

“The collar has a tracker inside it, so if anyone escapes, the Horde can find them,” she explained. “If any prisoners made it to our shop, my parents would disable the lock and then I would throw them in the river to send the Horde in the wrong direction.”

Catra turned the lock pick in her claws. “Well, I tried to unsheath my claws, but I think this thing is stopping me. So we can’t just slice them off. Do you think you could disable them?” She asked. “You must have seen your parents do it a lot!” Her mom, Cyra, always said that being a Queen was about identifying your subjects’ talents and setting them up to succeed. Adora wasn’t exactly her subject, but she was someone looking for help, Someone who trusted her, and, as a royalist operative, a member of the Alliance.

Adora looked unsure. “I don’t know,” she said. “Mom said I had to wait until my fine motor skills developed.”

“What does that mean?” Catra asked.

“I don’t know.” Adora replied.

“Well then” Catra argued. “How will you know you have those skills until you try? I’ve been old enough to let my claws grow out for months now. If I can handle ten sharp things, I’m sure you can handle one.”

Adora blinked and then broke out into a big grin. “Yeah! That makes sense.” She took the lock pick from her hand and started poking at the collar. Catra felt a little panel fall open. “You’ll have to do mine,” she commented. “So, listen to all the steps. First, I’m gonna pinch the yellow wire.”

Catra didn’t usually let people get this close to her, but she found Adora’s enthusiastic dorkiness weirdly soothing. When she was really focused on a step, she squinted and her tongue stuck out the side of her mouth. Catra’s giggling caused her to slip more than once.

“And then you disconnect the hydraulic cord and . . .” The collar came off with a satisfying click. “Presto!” She cried proudly. “Woo-

Hoo! Take that Hordak, you big dumb jerk!”

A loud pounding came from the other side of the wall. They jumped. “Shut up, you brats!” Grizzlor yelled. “If I hear you bad mouthing Hordak again, so help me I will send you to Shadow Weaver in a full body cast!”

Her face turned red. “Woo Hoo!” She whispered quietly, pumping her fist. “Ok, now your turn.”

Catra smiled right back at her. “I think we’re gonna be friends once we get out of here,” she whispered back.

“Best friends,” Adora agreed. “But how are we going to get out of here? And where are we going to go?”

Catra thought about it, then grinned excitedly. “Halfmoon has these super cool tunnels,” she whispered. “They lead all over Etheria. I’m sure we could find an entrance close by. We can have a sleepover in the palace while we wait for my mother to come back. I bet she’s saving your parents right now! And as for getting out of this truck,” she pointed to a slumbering, dark blue panther in another cell. “I think they’d be happy to help us once you get their collar off.”

A few minutes later, the doors to the Horde transport flew open, and two girls rode out into the darkness of the Whispering Woods on the back of a Krytan Battle Cat. It wouldn’t be the first time

they escaped the Horde’s clutches. Over the next few years, the risky raids they led on Horde caravans, bases, and prisons and their equally impressive escapes would become well known through the secret caves of Halfmoon.

When the princess first connected to her kingdom’s runestone, the two grew bolder, but their legend really began when they wandered back into the Whispering Woods one day, and Adora found a strange Sword.

Deep within the twisted steel corridors of the Fright Zone, two Horde cadets would hear stories of the two princesses and dream of being the ones to defeat them. The boy wanted to live up to everyone’s expectations of him, and the girl wanted to prove everyone's expectations of her wrong.

None of the four could have guessed how deeply their fates were intertwined.

Growing Up

Chapter Summary

> Horde Cadets Glimmer and Bow catch a glimpse of intruders, and the Alliance gains a familiar new ally.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The Outer Ring of the Fright Zone (or the Bright Zone as some called it in memory of the kingdom that had once stood there) was a muggy, swampy place, barely a mile from the dangerous Whispering Woods. However, the Horde believed that nature was merely an obstacle to be conquered. In the central districts, not a blade of grass could sprout up, but out here, mud and moss and critters with sharp teeth ate away at the rusted metal walkways and warehouses.

The great day moons were setting as the two cadets made their way down one of those walkways after a long day of drills. "Ok. That was the worst training ever," one of them huffed. "I take back everything bad I've ever said about the Simulators. I'd take on a thousand robots if I never had to run that obstacle course again."

The teenage boy walking with her looked around to see if any officers were in hearing range. It wouldn't have been the first time they got in trouble for talking out of turn. "I thought it was nice to spend some time outdoors at least," he said, rubbing his bruised arm. "It's refreshing. I swear all that smog is giving Kyle asthma."

"Oh yeah, Bow?" She challenged, pointing to his bare stomach. "How about when those great outdoors snagged your uniform and ripped off half your shirt? How refreshing was that?" The pink haired cadet kept her eyes on his abs for just long enough to make her cheeks turn red. She turned away and crossed her arms. "And of course, since leaving the strip of fabric on the climbing wall counted as 'leaving intel for the enemy' (because apparently Octavia decided she hates me for no reason), we all had to run the damn thing again! Not that getting a new one will be a problem for you."

"What's that supposed to mean, Glimmer?" He asked. "I bet Light Spinner is preparing a whole monologue for me about being more careful with Horde property as we speak."

"And at the end of that monologue," she said. "She'll have the commissary give everyone's favorite cadet a new uniform. If I wrecked my uniform, she'd give me the lecture, and ten extra shifts cleaning the commissary before she gave me the chance to steal a sewing kit from Hordak's Lab!"

Bow shrugged. His best friend was only half kidding. Light Spinner had been hard on her from day one. He knew why, but neither of them could say it out loud. "The Commander just expects more of you," he offered. "It'll get better once we're senior cadets." *And maybe if I make fewer stupid mistakes like I did on that obstacle course* he thought. *Whenever I disappoint her, she takes it out on you.*

Suddenly, Glimmer froze and pulled Bow behind a stack of crates. "Get down," she hissed. "I sense something."

Bow's eyes went wide. "Is it mag—" he cut himself off before he could say the forbidden word. "Err. Magnets?"

Glimmer closed her eyes. "Yeah," she confirmed. "It's *magnets* . But not like the moonstone or Light Spinner. This is different." She pointed to the closest storage facility. "In there," she whispered. "There's two of them. Come on."

Bow grabbe pad her arm. "Shouldn't we get a Force Captain?" He asked. "What if they're Princesses?"

"We can take a few Princesses," she insisted. "And think about it. If we catch them, Hordak will be so impressed he'll promote us right from junior cadets to Force Captain."

Bow scrunched his brow. "I don't think you can do that. Only senior cadets can become Force Captains, and we won't be senior cadets for another five years," he said. "And what those Princesses can brainwash people? Or shoot lasers out of their eyes? Or summon giant plant monsters? We're unarmed!"

"They're in a weapons warehouse!" She exclaimed. "We can grab some stun prods on the way in. And Lord Hordak can promote whoever to whatever he wants; that's why he's the lord," she argued. "Come on, let's go and get them before someone else—" The Intruder Alert Alarm cut her off. "Arrrg!"

Before they could react further, a pair of panicked girls their age burst out the side door. “Come on!” The Magicat shouted to the blonde, who was struggling with a pack of stolen loot. “The skiffs are this way!”

Glimmer and Bow leapt in their path. “Stop in the name of Lord Hordak, Rebels!” He shouted, just as Glimmer yelled, “Come at me!” But they were unarmed and exhausted. The blonde took advantage of that. Without skipping a stride, she grabbed a stun prod from her bag and chucked it at them. The prongs didn’t strike them, but they still jumped and fumbled to grab it. The opening was long enough for the Magicat to zip behind them faster than a hurricane.

Magic. The greater threat any Horde soldier could face.

Or so they thought. Because, when they turned to face the princess, the blonde took her staff and swept them off the walkways and into the muddy water below. “Take that, Horde Scum!” The Magicat shouted.

The blonde grabbed her hand. “No time to gloat,” she said urgently. “Let’s go!” And with that, they left the two cadets floating and shocked.

After a few moments, Glimmer finally broke the silence. “Yeah!” She called defiantly. “You better run!”

Queen Cyra of Halfmoon nodded to her advisors. “Give us the room,” she said. The half dozen magicat representatives of the major guilds bowed slightly as they exited, leaving the Queen alone with the golden princess who had just stepped out of myth and pledged her loyalty to the Princess Alliance.

“I want to thank you for saving my daughter, She-Ra,” Cyra said slyly. “Princess Catra tends not to admit when she needs help. But she made herself sound like quite the damsel in distress.”

According to Catra’s account, while the princess was innocently strolling through the woods (and absolutely not trying to steal Horde tech to give the Alliance an edge like she had done before several times), an entire Horde platoon descended on her position. The teenager was only able to fight off half of them before things began to look dire. Then, out of the Woods, the mythical warrior She-Ra emerged and drove them all off. Needless to say, as impressed as she was with the princess, Cyra couldn’t help but find the blonde woman . . . familiar.

She-Ra fidgeted. The strange glow that emanated from her white armor illuminated amber crystals that studded the walls of the throne room. Ever since they moved underground, artificial light from the crystals had become critical to Halfmoon.

“Well, your highness,” she said in an obviously artificially lowered voice. “Your daughter is very special. I was honored to save her from that platoon of Horde soldiers. Honestly, it was more of a team effort. You must have trained her super well. In fact, I think you should let her join me on my She-Ra adventures.”

Cyra raised an eyebrow. “Really?” She asked.

She-Ra nodded. “Yes,” she answered. “With her runestone magic and my . . . She-Ra magic, we could do a ton of damage to the Horde. Safely!”

“Hmmm.” The Queen made a show of considering the offer. “I don’t know. You should probably talk over your proposal with Adora. She is Catra’s main adventure partner right now, and you wouldn’t want to step on her toes. Those two are pretty close.”

The princess rocked back on her heels. “Oh, I already spoke to Adora, ma’am,” she explained. “And she loves the idea! Totally on-board with the whole thing.”

“Really?” Cyra said. “You talked to yourself?” The princess sputtered for a response. “Come on, Adora. I know it’s you under there.”

“How did you know?” Adora asked, wide-eyed, sheepishly lowering the sword and returning to her true form: a lanky fourteen year old girl, dressed in the same simple modified Magicat scouting gear she usually wore.

“Honestly,” the Queen responded. “I was sixty— maybe seventy percent sure, but you just confirmed it.” When she smiled, Cyra looked exactly like her daughter when one of her long-shot plans to slip by Horde soldiers succeeded. “Now, can you tell me the

truth? I've heard the legends of She-Ra, and I know magic when I sense it. That wasn't just some First One's hologram."

Adora sighed. "When Catra and I were coming back from a scouting mission yesterday, I kept hearing this weird voice." She rubbed the back of her neck. "Catra thought I just had a concussion I got from when the skiff we stole crashed—"

"Sounds like quite the exciting *scouting* mission." Cyra couldn't stop herself from interjecting. Ever since Catra developed a connection with Halfmoon's runestone, she and her friend had been bolder in their missions against the Horde, after Cyra had spent years pulling what remained of the Alliance in a more defensive direction.

Adora blushed. "Yes," she said. "It started as a scouting mission. I swear. We were both really careful! But someone spotted us, and we had to get out quick so we ran away but there were these Horde soldiers and—"

She swallowed hard and continued. "The point is, Catra started to sense some magic too. And we followed it, and found this sword, and when I touched it I heard someone talking about balance and it asked if I would fight for the Honor of Grayskull and I said yes and then whoosh I'm wearing a tiara and—"

"Breathe, Adora," Cyra ordered. She had considered the girl to be her ward for five years now. Catra had brought her to the emergency tunnels that the Magicats would relocate to after they had met on a Horde transport, both captured by the forces that

were rounding up all magic users they could find. Since then, the girls had been inseparable. Even after her parents arrived with a group of escapees, Adora spent much of her time getting into trouble with the princess.

As the kid took a few deep breaths to stave off hyperventilating, the queen turned her head to the stalactites hanging on the chamber ceiling. “Catra,” she sighed. “You can come out now too.”

Suddenly, a pair of mismatched eyes appeared in the darkness and from the heights leapt the crown Princess of Halfmoon, dressed in a gem-toned suit of silk-padded armor, a signature of Magicat warriors. With an agility that fully-initiated warriors would find hard to beat, she rolled into the fall and popped up beside her best friend without incident. The purple sash, a deep shade matching her mother’s robes, which marked her as a true-born member of the royal family barely fluttered.

“Seriously, Mom?” She groaned. “How did you even know I was up there?”

The Queen crossed her arms. “The Twilight Topaz isn’t just about hiding yourself, Catra,” she explained. “If you spent more time exploring your powers and less time blowing stuff up, you would know that.”

Catra rolled her eyes. “For what it’s worth, we are blowing up *Horde* stuff, ma’am,” Adora offered. “And Catra is learning more about her powers all the time. She can see in the dark now! She

figured out how to do it when we got cornered in this factory, and I had to kill the lights to cover our escape. It was—"

Catra's furious 'cut it out' gestures finally caught her attention. Adora blushed apologetically.

"What Adora means to say, is that I don't learn magic from spending time in the library." Catra said. "I learn by doing. I'll never master the Twilight Stone if you keep me from the action!"

Cyra rubbed her temples. The many-jeweled Crown of Theodora weighed heavily on her head. "I just want you to be safe," the queen said. "Both of you."

"How can I ever be safer than with She-Ra watching my back?" She demanded. "Now that Adora has her own crazy magic, we'll be unstoppable together. We can stop the Horde from taking more territory and prisoners and . . ." The princess looked over to the gold-flecked mosaic mural decorating the throne room's western wall. The one honoring the first Princess Alliance, and the woman who was the driving force behind it: Catra's mother, Cyra's wife, Halfmoon's other Queen: Moira.

The three all fell silent for a few minutes. Adora's parents had been among those freed from the internment camps after the last real attack the Princess Alliance carried out, but there had been no word of the Queen's fate. It didn't take long for the kingdom to accept that the worst had happened.

“You are not the only ones who learn from experience, girls,” Cyra said at last, not taking her eyes off the mosaic. “Each time you attack, they learn more about you. Believe me, the Horde will discover new ways to catch you faster than you discover new ways to evade them.” She turned back to face them. “I order you to stay within Alliance territory until further notice. Until I see fit to sanction your missions, you are not to go anywhere near Horde-occupied territory. Do otherwise, and I will confine you both to the caverns indefinitely.”

Both tried to interject, but she held a hand to silence them. “However, I understand your need for practice. So, if the odd patrol or supply convoy crosses into Halfmoon’s protected lands: the Whispering Woods, the Meadowlands, or the Redwood Revine, then you may use your discretion.”

Adora and Catra shared a smile. “Thank you, ma’am!” Adora said. “I promise: no more sneaking into the Fright Zone!”

“Not that we admit to having done that,” Catra added, with a quick elbow to her friend’s side. “Seriously, how are you this bad at lying?” She added in a whisper she wrongly believed Cyra could not hear. “You folded faster than a napkin earlier.”

“We didn’t rehearse what to say if she said she knew who I was,” Adora defended in a slightly louder whisper. “Next time, we have to go over more potential scenarios.”

“As for the Rebellion’s newest princess,” Cy’ra said, concealing a laugh. “I think it would be best if we kept your true identity a

secret. I will ensure you both have full access to the restricted sections of the royal archives for your research, but until you are ready for the field, it will be better to keep an air of mystery around She-Ra." And it will allow her to have something of a normal childhood, but Cyra didn't say that part. "Of course, if you wish to tell Marlena and Randor, that is up to you."

Adora nodded. "Ok," she agreed. "I think I'll keep it from Mom and Dad for now. They get worried whenever I leave the house. I don't think they'd take this well."

"Have Catra supervise, then," the queen deadpanned.

"Don't worry," Catra said, putting an arm around her friend. "I think we can come up with a cover story."

"Now," Cyra put her hands together. "I actually have a good starter mission for you both. Our allies on the surface have reported sightings of a strange, winged, foal with a horn running amok. Apparently, it has been breaking open stable doors en masse."

Adora blushed and shared a strange, knowing look with Catra. "W-what?" She stammered. "That sounds crazy. I wonder where something like that could have come from. . ." Cyra raised an eyebrow, but Catra started talking before she could press the issue.

“Great talk, Mom,” she said quickly, backing out with Adora on her arm. “Gotta go! Duty calls. See you for dinner!”

“You won’t regret this, ma’am,” Adora added. “We’ll have that majestic creature back here in no time!”

As they left, she heard a familiar whistle as her daughter called for her battle cat. “Come on Melog!” She shouted. “You get a second shot at Horsey!”

Far away from the safety of Halfmoon, in another dark underground sanctum, a voice echoed within an empty chamber.

“Conducting Potential Administrator Evaluation,” it said robotically. An image of Adora and Catra trying to wrangle a rainbow-colored foal flashed on the wall and froze. “Error: Personality Profile. Administrator: She-Ra.” The image zoomed in on the girls’ laughing faces. “Attachment Level to Planet (Etheria): Dangerously High and Growing. Malleability to Authority: Low. Acceptance of Command Structures: Low. Need for Validation: Met. Tendency to Self-Sacrifice: Potential for Growth, but Moderate and Managed. Chance of Rejection of Heart of Etheria Project . . . Unacceptable.”

The room was silent for hours. Then, the voice spoke again. “Administrator: She-Ra cannot be trusted to Balance the Planet. Initiate Administrator: Override.” The room flashed red and the walls shook. A golden glow seeped through the floors, and on the surface a sudden storm raged above the Whispering Woods. Then, as quickly as it came, the room returned to normal. “Error:

She-Ra Assignment already confirmed. Planetary Interference. Attempt to Revoke Credentials: Failed.” More silence.

“Balance Must be Restored,” the voice said. “The Heart of Etheria Project must be completed.” It paused. “Administrator: She-Ra only needs to be Active to achieve this goal.” The image on the wall vanished. “Altering Parameters . . . Alter ‘Train She-Ra’ to ‘Train Etherian Substitute.’ Temporary Administrator Profile: Created. Seeking Similar Personality Profile with Acceptable Elements.”

The computers whirred loudly as the ancient mechanisms processed all the possibilities. Millions of faces flashed across the wall. At last, it landed on the image of two Horde cadets standing on a balcony smiling. The image focused on the boy’s face. “Personality Profile: Acceptable. Administrator: Bow, Designated.”

With her new target established, the Voice began to make plans.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you for reading! If you enjoyed this chapter, consider leaving a kudos or a comment. They are all wonderful!

It's back! I only have one other chapter planned for the immediate future, but please tell me what scenes you would want to see in this AU! Next time, we'll see how Light Hope plans to accommodate Bow into her machinations and what happens once the girls grow up and start becoming more of a threat (Glimmer included)

As for feedback, since this is a bit shorter I'd be happy to answer any questions you have about how this AU works. I made the Magicats different than I did in Full Moon Fever.

Here, I was going for more of a Byzantine/Eastern Roman Empire feel for them instead of Greek/Egyptian. Also, if there are any specific scenes or scenarios you'd be interested in seeing this universe's version of: let me know, in case I end up turning this into a collection of alternate episodes instead of attempting to rewrite five seasons. . . ha ha! unless . . .

As always, thanks for reading. Have a great weekend. May we all be vaccinated quickly!

Visions

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

As the Planetary Administrator attempted to revoke her access to the Sword of Protection, Adora felt a slight pain in her chest, but it vanished before she even thought to mention it, replaced by the constant pulsing spark that was quickly becoming comforting.

But to the foal, who was already grappling with a couple of major stressors at the moment, it was terrifying. He bolted away from the strangers.

"Horsey!" Adora called. "Come back! We're not gonna hurt you."

The foal kept running. He knew this person was different. Instead of an incoherent stream of grunts, he understood what she was trying to say, as if she was a member of his herd. All people had sounded different ever since the Magic One's sword had blasted him, but deep down, his instincts told him to trust her in particular. But the foal had had enough of people.

"What's wrong with that thing?" Catra yelled, as she caught up. "Can't it tell we're the good guys?"

"No," Adora panted, running after it. "Horsey is really scared of us." As she explained, the foal in question took off flying.

“Duh!” Catra yelled back, closing the gap immediately. “I didn’t know one of She-Ra’s titles was Princess Obvious!”

“It’s more than that,” Adora explained, skidding to a hard stop as the foal vanished into the canopy of the Whispering Woods. “It’s like I can hear his feelings. Does that make sense?”

Melog meowed. “I mean,” Catra replied. “I thought that was just a Magicat and Kyrtan thing, but . . . That does sound familiar, doesn’t it buddy?” Melog chirruped happily. “Maybe that sword gave him more than wings?”

Adora nodded. “Yeah,” she sighed. “Maybe.” They had been tracking Horsey for hours now, and this was the latest near miss. Dusk light filtered through the dense canopy of the Whispering Woods. Crickets and other night critter had begun chirping and chattering. Soon, the day moons would set and it would be even harder to capture the foal before it attacked another farm. Adora’s first mission as She-Ra wasn’t exactly shaping up to be legendary.

Melog let out a long meow. For most Halfmooners, it was the kind he used when he wanted attention— which did all the time— because most Halfmooners couldn’t understand him. Even to those steeped in the lore of Etherian magic, Kyrtans were strange beasts. According to legend, they were once the trusted companions of each member of the royal Magicat family. The purple robes that marked their status were a direct reference to their majestic coats. However, over the ages, they became scarce. Melog was the only one most Halfmooners had ever seen.

And as if Melog wasn't special enough, on the night of their escape from the Horde, he had imprinted on Catra and forged a bond stronger than any. Sometimes, Adora even got a little jealous of him. "Good point, buddy," Catra responded to a conversation no one else on Etheria could understand. "If you have a bond with that thing, do you think you can track it? Like Melog does for me?"

Adora closed her eyes and tried to focus. At first, nothing happened, but then, slowly, she started to feel a second heartbeat pounding next to her own. She followed a thread extending from that second heart into the nearby mountains, twisting through the cliffs and caves until she found him.

Adora's eyes snapped open. "I know where he is."

From there, the two friends tracked the foal to its hiding place in the Cat Claw Heights. The only foliage that grew this high up was scrubby bushes and cacti. "Not exactly good food for a growing horse," Adora commented.

"I don't think that's what Horsey has been eating," Catra replied. The rocky ground outside of the cave was littered with apple cores. Flies buzzed around the older ones. "I guess we were in an orchard when you zapped him. Makes sense he keeps going back there."

Adora blushed. “Do you mind staying outside for this?” She asked. “I think it would be easier to approach him on my own.”

Melog meowed indignantly. He was basically the Mayor of Halfmoon. He spent most of his days making rounds through the corridors, stopping at heavily trafficked intersections and lounging luxuriously for his adoring public. Even when he was napping in a secluded spot, if anyone came up to him he would be sure to stretch and pose in his sleep.

Melog was beloved by all, and if anyone could charm this wayward creature, it was him.

“I know, I know,” Adora reassured him. “You are, without a doubt, the cutest gentleman in the Rebellion, and no one can change that.” Melog meowed in agreement. “But Horsey is really skittish, and I think he wouldn’t react too well to too many people.

“Besides,” Catra said. “We need you out here in case he tries to escape again. I’ve seen you catch plenty of birds before.” They were all stuffed toys on string, but still Melog was pretty good at catching them.

Alone, Adora walked into the cave and found Horsey.

The foal backed away, whinnying. Memories flashed through his head of the last human who caught him— *being torn away from his herd, taken to a dark place with dirty air and poisoned water,*

breaking out just long enough to escape to his herd's pasture only to find the grass turned to ash .

Suddenly, She-Ra froze and held out her hand. "The Horde hurt you," she said, pointing to the. "They took away your home, didn't they?"

The foal stomped its hooves. "Yeah," she replied. The Warrior lowered her sword and suddenly the golden glow around her faded and she shrank down to a less intimidating size. "I know what that's like," she continued. "When I was a kid, the Horde took away my home . ." The foal relaxed somewhat but didn't budge. She scrunched her brow. "You showed me," she muttered, stretching out her hand again. "So maybe I can—"

A bright village poisoned by smog. Eviction orders with blood red warnings. Fleeing at the first sign of soldiers. Losing another home when they found them again. Screams. Running until her legs couldn't carry her. Struggling as they tazed, collared, and caged her.

Then, waking up panicked in a cool bedroom, tip-toeing downstairs and putting an ear to her parents' room, listening for their breathing— making sure they're still there. That no one had come and taken them again.

"See?" Adora asked the foal, tears in her eyes. "We're the same." The foal took a step toward her. "Halfmoon has built a place for refugees like us, a place where we can be safe, where we don't

have to run.” The foal inched forward, still uncertain. He looked at his wings.

Adora winced and pointed to her sword. “Sorry about that,” she said. “We’re both new to this whole magic thing.”

To her surprise, the foal shook his head vigorously. “You had magic before?” She asked. More head shaking. A new image came to her head, a dream instead of a memory: *Horde soldiers fleeing before an ocean of charging horses. Leading them, a mighty flying stallion, the size of a dragon.* “Oh!” She exclaimed excitedly. “You like the wings because you want to fight the Horde! That’s why you’re trying to break open the stables! You’re making a horse army!” He whinnied triumphantly. and flapped his wings.

“Catra, Melog, and I fight the Horde all the time!” Adora continued. “Come with us! Together, we can be unstoppable.” Still skittish, the foal placed its muzzle against her hand. Minutes passed, but she didn’t move. She didn’t try to hurt him. The bond between them grew stronger. Then, slowly, he began to nuzzle her. “Welcome to the family, Horsey.”

From outside the mouth of the cave, Adora heard Melog give a discontented meow. Catra leaned into the cave. “He’s right,” she said. “If your mutant horse is joining the team, he needs a better name. No Horde soldier is ever gonna be scared of She-Ra and her valiant steed Horsey.”

The foal stamped his hooves heartily. “See?” Catra bragged. “He agrees.”

“Umm. Well, I’m sure I can come up with a better name,” Adora said as she stroked his mane. “Like ummm . . . Clip-Clop . . .Flip-Flap. . . Horse-Ra?”

“Swift Wind,” the foal said with conviction, saving her from suggesting any more names.

“Swift Wind!” Adora exclaimed. “That’s perf—“ she pulled away and looked the foal in the eyes. “Did you just talk or did the Sword make me crazy?”

The foal hesitated. “Y-Yes,” he said, clearly struggling to put words together. “It’s . . . new.”

After a few moments of gaping, Adora managed to pick her jaw off the floor. “Don’t worry,” she said. “It’s new to us too.” She hugged the foal again, and this time, he responded by wrapping his wings around her. “Welcome to the family, *Swift Wind.* ”

In the background, Catra and Melog were still reeling. Melog nervously rubbed up against Catra’s side. “Don’t worry, buddy,” she said, pushing past her dry throat. “I guarantee people are gonna be too freaked out by the talking to think he’s cuter than you.” Melog growled. “And also he isn’t as fluffy as you, so nothing to worry about.”

---Five Years Later ---

The cadets crested the ridge, moving as silently as possible. Their leader gestured for the others to hold as he peered into the valley below. The squad was alone in a dark, dangerous stretch of the Whispering Woods— cut off from potential reinforcements. The last orders they received were to track a missing supply convoy, grab whatever weapons were left, and record exactly how all the soldiers had brutally died from local wildlife.

"Lonnie, Rogelio, you take the flanks," Bow ordered, pointing to a small pillar of smoke billowing out of the trees. "Kyle, watch our six. Glimmer and I will go ahead and draw out any stragglers. We got reports of Princesses in the debrief, so keep your eyes peeled."

The team nodded and fanned out. Each cadet kept their guard up, eyes flicking between the indicators on their googles and the spooky shadows on the twisted forest floor. They had heard stories of what happened to convoys that went through these woods, or any territory currently under the thumb of the evil Magicat Queen. She had a stable of horrible servants at her command: a winged beast with a spear coming out of its head, a shadowy apprentice with bloody claws and a fiendish feline, and worst of all a giant, half-mad, sword-wielding monster known as She-Ra.

As they moved forward, a shadow creeped up on their position. Kyle turned and saw it. He gasped, readied his stun prod, and fired.

Suddenly, the scene froze. The squad leader stepped away from the video he just paused. “Ok team,” Bow asked. “What went wrong here?”

His battered squad mates just kept lying back at their desks. The classroom they secured for this exercise wasn’t comfortable, but nowhere in the Horde was and the exercise had left them exhausted. But Bow, as always, was wide awake— even after taking a beating in the simulator and an earful of whatever Light Spinner said to him after a failure.

“It was something Kyle did,” Glimmer volunteered.

Bow nodded. “Ok, good,” he said. “And what was that?”

“Being Kyle,” Lonnie offered. The team snickered as Kyle turned red.

“I panicked!” He defended. “The last time I saw a shadow move like that, it turned out to be a princess and killed us all!”

“Well, this time it wasn’t the shadow of the Princess of Halfmoon,” Bow explained. “It was a regular shadow.” He clicked the video back on and let the events play out as he narrated them. “And when you shot at it, you alerted the Princesses to our presence, allowing them to swoop in on Lonnie and Rogelio before they were in position, corner us, and blast us into next week.”

“We might have stood a chance if Glimmer hadn’t flubbed her attack,” Lonnie interjected. “Seriously what was that thing with your hands? I think it made the room shock you!”

“Look,” Glimmer defended, trying to deflect from the subject. “The whole point of these simulators is to make us better. Try things, they don’t work out, try something else! We’ll just be ready next time.

“Besides,” she said dismissively. “I still think She-Ra is a myth, like the Headless Princess. I mean, a giant woman with a huge sword smashing into our supply convoys? Seems pretty far-fetched.”

Suddenly, the speaker screeched on. “Attention Cadets,” the voice rang out. “All Horde soldiers below Force Captain rank will be restricted to brown ration bars until further notice. Contrary to Rebel Propaganda, this is NOT because of supply line interference by She-Ra. On an unrelated note, the reward for capturing the Princess of Power has doubled. Long Live Lord Hordak!”

The groans could be heard in every corner of the Fright Zone.

Bow clapped. “Yeah, team! Consider that motivation!” Bow cheered. “All of Etheria has to deal with those magical tyrants wrecking their homes, burning their fields, and stealing their best ration bars. Someday soon, we’ll get the chance to face She-Ra and her allies in the field, conquer Halfmoon, and take! Them! Back!”

A few members of the squad gave half-hearted cheers. Glimmer's was the loudest. "Won't the bars be stale by then?" Kyle asked.

Bow sighed. "Work with me, Kyle!" He cried. "Work with me!"

Later that night, Bow tossed and turned in his bunk. Around midnight, Glimmer trudged back in from the magic lessons no one else was supposed to know about. Bow winced as he listened to her footsteps. He didn't look up, but he could hear her limping.

"It's nothing," she whispered, seeing right through his "I'm really asleep act". "You know how Light Spinner gets after simulator failures. Don't see why that's my fault. If she let me use my . . . *magnets* , we'd wipe the floor with Queen Cyra— bots wouldn't stand a chance."

"But then everyone would know about you know . . . *that* ," Bow argued. "People might be scared of you."

"You're not scared of me!" She shot back. "And maybe that would be a good thing. At least then, people would respect me. Not that Mr. Soon-to-be-Force-Captain over here would need to worry about that."

"I'm not— it's not a sure thing." He responded.

Glimmer sighed. “Don’t be modest, Bow,” she said. “Light Spinner practically showed me your badge. I’d bet three months latrine duty that you’ll get the good news this week. Then, they’ll be plastering your face on every poster in Section 7G.” Bow kept himself from wincing. Field duty. He was . . . he was ready for that. Right? Of course he was. He had to be. Bringing order to Etheria, defending his friends, it was his purpose in life— the reason the Horde had taken him as a baby.

And now, every time he failed to be perfect, his friends wouldn’t just come away with some scrapes and mild electrical burns. They could die, and it would be all his fault.

“Before that . . . I have something that might cheer you up,” he said, masking his panic. “I thought we could use a break after everything today.”

Glimmer rolled her eyes. “Let me guess,” she cackled. “You smuggled in a pack of cards? How exciting!”

Bow grinned right back and held up a skiff key. “Something like that,” he said smugly. He would never live his attempt at a wild Junior Cadet Grad Night, but he thought this might make for a better story. “I mean, we could wait until I actually get the badge to have a joy ride, but like you said, the poster photo shoots might take up all of my time.”

Glimmer grabbed the key out his hands. “I take back everything said,” she whispered ecstatically. “You’re awesome; let’s go!”

And so the two friends went out into the wilds on a stolen skiff. They didn't know it yet, but it would be the last time. And not because of Bow's upcoming promotion.

Because once they got deep into the tangle of the Whispering Woods, Glimmer lost control of the skiff. Because Bow flew off into the dark roots and shadows. Because he saw a strange arrow sticking out of the earth, and when he tried to walk towards it, he had a vision.

Thousands of archers flashed before his eyes. A lithe, golden-haired bronze young man unleashing lightning bolts into an enormous snake draped over a marble shrine. A dark-skinned prince in a chariot charging into battle with a god at his side. Another warrior shooting down giant, blazing suns that were burning the planet. A green-glad yeoman in the shade of the woods with a band at his side, driving the real thieves out of his home.

"Will you accept the Power of Apollo?" A strange voice said. "Will you bring Balance to Etheria, Bow?"

Before he could answer, Glimmer shook him awake, terrified that he might have brain damage. Once she was mostly sure he was fine, she jabbed him in the shoulder and laughed. "Better get home before Light Spinner realizes we're gone," she said. "Please don't say anything crazy to her." Bow wanted to believe her. Wanted to write off everything as just a fever dream from a bumpy skiff ride and overwhelming stress, but he just couldn't.

When Light Spinner put the Force Captain’s badge in his hand, all the visions came flooding back. The promise of a power strong enough to always keep his friends safe - to never let the Horde down - to bring balance to Etheria once and for all. Or maybe just confirmation that it was all a dream.

Whatever he was really seeking, the next time Bow went into the skiff, he was alone.

Chapter End Notes

I'm trying to keep these chapters on the shorter side. I hope you still enjoyed it. If you did, leave a comment or kudos. They inspire me to keep writing.

I dropped a few hints at what form Light Hope's plan for Bow will take. Next time, we'll see more of that (and close out for the time being) and see what one of those convoy raids looks like from Adora and Catra's point of view.

Until next time, stay safe! And good luck to whatever team you're cheering for in the Olympic Games!

The Power of Apollo

Chapter Summary

Bow meets a pair of Rebels in the Whispering Woods and gets more than he bargained for.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Back in the Fright Zone, Bow had a reputation for being an optimist. No matter how rough things got, he was always there for his squad with a rousing speech to keep them going. Every failure was just a chance to improve in his eyes. It wasn't a very common attitude. In fact, he could have sworn he'd caught Kyle rolling his eyes at one point, but he refused to give up hope.

But now, even Force Captain Bow had to admit that being marched through enemy territory by some of the Horde's most notorious foes wasn't exactly the best way to start his officer career. If Bow was to watch a replay of this little impromptu mission of his, he would have a few notes for himself.

First, when he encountered the two Rebels in the Woods, he should have paused and assessed the situation. He should not have yelled and charged straight at them.

Second, when he realized that one of the Rebels was a princess, he should have retreated and sought backup, or at least changed his strategy based on that information. He should not have kept running towards the glowing weapon in a desperate attempt to snatch it from them.

Third, when he did grap the bow and immediately have a vision of strange archers while hearing a weird voice before passing out, he should have. . . not done that? He tested the makeshift ropes keeping his hands bound and shook his head. Yeah, at that point he doesn't know what he could have done differently.

"So," the blonde Rebel asked. "You've been pretty quiet, Horde spy. Do they not have small talk in the Fright Zone?"

"I prefer not to exchange pleasantries with my captors," he replied. "According to standard procedure, I can give you my name and rank, but that's it."

"Standard procedure? You get captured that often, Arrow Boy?" The princess quipped, twirling the weapon in her claws. "Guess we don't have much to worry about."

"My name is Bow!" He shot back. "And I'll have you know I haven't been captured before. I know the procedure because all Horde soldiers are prepared for anything at all times."

The Rebels shared a look, then started cackling. "What's so funny?" Bow demanded.

"Your name is seriously Bow?" The blonde asked. "What does the Horde just let the kids name themselves? Or are you all named

after weapons?”

Actually, the Horde did allow junior cadets to invent their own surnames for pure record keeping purposes, but he was not about to surrender the point. “There’s nothing silly about my name or any other Horde soldiers’,” Bow protested, pointing at the princess. “Her name is *Cat* -ra! How’s that for on the nose?”

“Yeah, Adora,” Catra said, barely restraining another laugh. “Horde names are perfectly normal. Just ask his brother Stun Prod.” Another round of laughter erupted. Before Bow could come up with a retort, the princess walked away. “Kaygrove should be close,” she told her companion. “I’ll scout ahead. You keep an eye on Dagger.”

The two walked a few minutes in silence. Bow took the chance to get a better look at his captors. The princess was unarmed, except for the bow across her back and whatever dark powers she had at her command. She and the other Rebel acted like squad mates, but Bow knew that a tyrant like her would never consider a regular Etherian to be her equal; so, the blonde was probably a servant of some kind. Maybe a bodyguard. That would explain why she carried a fine-looking saber at her hip. For some reason, the blue jewel in the gilt hilt seemed familiar.

Before he could remember where he had seen it before, the princess ahead of them growled frustratedly as she checked a series of markings on an unassuming tree.

“Why are you serving her?” Bow asked quietly, hoping Adora could be reasoned with. The Horde had taught Bow to have sympathy for Etherians like her. After all, that’s who they were trying to help. Sure, she was a Rebel, but she had probably been brainwashed into it since childhood, or at least threatened into obedience. Once they saw the truth, who wouldn’t go over to the right side of the war?

“Because she’s my friend,” Adora answered with a puzzled frown, like she didn’t understand the question. “Also she’s kinda my boss since my family resettled in Halfmoon.” She scrutinized him again. “Or do you mean, ‘Why do I fight for the Rebellion?’”

Now Bow was confused. Those were the same thing. Anyone under the Princesses command was obviously forced to fight for them against the Horde. “She’s a princess,” he explained. “They’re dangerous, evil instigators who can’t control their own powers. Aren’t you worried she’ll vaporize you or something? It’s not like you’re a princess.”

“Yep,” Adora responded hastily. “I am definitely not a princess. That said, have you actually met a princess before? Because that description doesn’t fit any of the ones I’ve met.”

“Well,” Bow huffed. “You really don’t need to meet them to know. Why else would the Horde have to bring order to Etheria if the Princesses weren’t bringing chaos?”

Now it was her time to huff. “Yeah yeah. ‘Bringing order to Etheria’,” she said sarcastically. “Is that what the Horde was doing

when they drove my family from our home? When they made being a First One a crime? When they kidnapped every magic-user they could find? Tell me, how was that orderly?”

Bow flinched. “You’re a First One!” He exclaimed, his eyes darting across her. “But you— how— you’re not—“

“Not a void-born monster?” She finished. “Not cackling at my secret plan to destroy Etheria?” Her face softened a bit, but she still looked ready to fight. “I assume the propaganda hasn’t changed in the last decade.”

“No,” Bow defended. “I learned about them. The Horde tried to tolerate the First Ones, but they kept sabotaging Hordak’s mission. They didn’t give us a choice.”

“I was wrong,” she said exasperatedly. “Somehow the propaganda got stupider!”

Before he could respond, they heard an anguished cry through the brush. When the rushed forward, they found the princess kneeling beside charred rubble. The clearing was full of it— broken bricks, rotted thatch, and bits of shattered glass. Adora walked forward and picked up a banner with strange lettering. “Mara’s Dragon,” she muttered. “From the Scalewing Fleet.” She wrapped up the cloth slowly. “We had a neighbor from that fleet when I was a kid. They must have settled here after the Purges.”

“What happened here?” Bow asked, dazed by the destruction. The princess whirled around to face him. Even Lord Hordak couldn’t match the glare she gave him.

“Don’t play dumb, Horde spy!” She shouted, a threatening growl building in her throat. “You were probably part of the raid that destroyed this village.”

“I’ve never left the Fright Zone before,” he protested. “And the Horde wouldn’t do this. You Princesses are the ones who mindlessly destroy, not us.”

With his hands bound, Bow couldn’t do much when Catra tackled him to the ground. The impact knocked the wind from his lungs. She extended her claws and slashed down, but Adora grabbed her wrist before she could reach his face. “Catra, no!” She ordered. “You’re better than this.”

“You think I’m a monster?” She growled at the prisoner. For a second, Bow thought he saw tears in her eyes. “Well how do you explain that?” She pointed her unrestrained hand at one of the only walls still standing. A pair of crimson bat wings, the same that were emblazoned on the back of his shirt, had been sprayed on the stone like a brand.

Bow’s throat closed at the sight.

The princess stood up roughly, kneeing him in the stomach on the way. “You’ll have plenty of time to hear about the Horde’s crimes in the Halfmoon dungeons,” she declared as she stormed off. “Let’s get moving before any of his friends show up.”

“I don’t understand,” Bow said, mostly to himself. “The Horde couldn’t have done this. Why would they? What would they gain?”

Adora showed him the banner. “Maybe it was because a clan of First Ones came here. Maybe they wanted to keep them from joining the Rebellion,” she suggested. “Or maybe it was just in the way. Trust me, the Horde doesn’t need a reason to wreck lives.”

Bow shook his head. “But that’s . . .” He looked back at the wings again. “You don’t know the Horde like I do. They took me in when I was an orphan. They raised me, gave me a home. They aren’t bad people.”

Adora packed away the banner and stared at him hard. Her eyes held a mix of anger and pity. “Maybe you just don’t know the Horde as well as you think,” she said. As she reached out to help him up, the ground quaked, shaking the remaining rubble.

“Um. Is Causing Minor earthquakes her power?” Bow asked. Before Adora could respond, a monster burst into the clearing.

Bow had seen some terrors in the simulators, but this beast was worse than any giant princess the Horde programmers could

conjure. The beetle was all sharp angles and sharper edges. It looked like a pile of disused tanks got up and crawled out of the scrap yards.

Suddenly, the Rebels didn't see Bow as the main threat.

Catra charged in first, zipping from one spot to another faster than he could blink. Her claws left deep marks on its carapace. Adora rushed in to give back up, but she didn't seem to be needed. At first, the beetle just flailed in response to the princess' onslaught— its massive pincers too slow to catch her.

Bow took the chance to cut his bonds on a jagged bit of the ruins.

Then, just as the vines around his wrist snapped, the beetle got in a lucky hit, sending the princess flying hard into a nearby tree and the weapon into the center of the clearing. "Catra, no!" Adora called out to her in shock. Before she could run to her, the beetle snapped its pincers around her torso and lifted her up into the air. If she hadn't managed to wedge her sword in just right, the beast would have snapped her in half.

As it stood, she had maybe a minute.

While they were occupied, Bow rushed forward and grabbed the enchanted weapon. All he had to do was get it back to the Fright Zone and give it to Light Spinner. Then this whole thing would be over, and everything could go back to normal. The moment his

fingers touched the grip, he was teleported away from the chaos into a white void. Before him stood a strange woman draped in cold colored robes.

"I am Light Hope," the glowing woman told him. Visions flashed before his eyes: of blazing dots in the void, of Crystal spires, of comets streaking through the night. "Etheria needs a champion, Bow. Will you be that champion? Will you fight with the Power of Apollo?"

"I don't understand," the force Captain responded. "Who are you? Who's Apollo?"

"You will understand in time," she said. "Once you accept the power."

Then, the light blazed brighter and brighter until he couldn't see anything but a white void. He tried to close his eyes, but in the vision he was frozen. Bow could only feel the waves of power crash against him over and over again, like he was stuck in the surf during a hurricane.

Just when he thought he couldn't take anymore, he planted his feet, raised the strange bow above his head, and shouted.

"By the Power of Apollo!" Suddenly, the waves weren't fighting him. They were within him. "I have the power!"

With that declaration, a bolt of energy struck the weapon like a lightning rod, spreading through his bones like the molten metal in the Fright Zone's factories. Bow's cadet uniform melted into something lighter and less restrictive. His limbs lengthened. His muscles grew. Even his hair felt cooler.

Seeing him, the Rebels' jaws dropped to the floor. The giant beetle paused its thrashing. It turned its head to the side curiously, dropped Adora, and backed away slowly.

"When did you grow a mustache!" Catra yelled, having quickly gotten over the life-threatening peril. "And what's with the crop top?"

Before he could take the chance to admire his new facial hair and fashion choices, Bow came crashing back to reality. The weapon had transformed him. A quiver of arrows had appeared on his back. His uniform was now a set of gold and white armor with a heart embossed on his chest (and nothing covering his midriff). He was also somehow glowing.

Force Captain Bow, Golden Child of the the Horde, had just saved Rebels. And a princess.

With magic.

Magic that he used.

To save them.

It wouldn’t be long before the three would look back at this moment and laugh. But for now, All at once, they started screaming in panic.

And that just made the giant stag beetle angry all over again.

Chapter End Notes

Apologies for the long wait! Between the start of school and the job search for next summer, things have been hectic. In person school is great, but it turns out all the time spent walking everywhere cuts into my writing schedule . . .

This was a fun idea to explore, and I hope to do more in the future. Stay tuned for that. In the meantime, I think I've left you all dangling on Straight Into Darkness' cliffhanger for a bit too long. . . Hopefully, posting this will help me get back into the groove and make some progress on the final installment of Full Moon Fever. Still, forgive me if I'm a bit slower in posting that than I've been in the past.

Thanks for reading! Leave a kudos or comment if you enjoyed this AU. Your feedback fuels my creative fires!

End Notes

Thanks for reading! If you enjoyed (and want to see more of this AU in the future) leave a kudos or comment. They inspire me to keep writing.

The idea of this roleswap has been kicking around in my head for a while now. I had a lot of fun writing just this scene, but I have a few more ideas. . . mainly Horde Glimmer and Horde Bow for those sweet, sweet character foils! For now, all I have is this one shot. Let me know if you would be interested in seeing more.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!